It didn’t make up for being beaten but I was pleased about my goal that night. I’d skipped away from Roberto Carlos and arrowed one into the top corner. I’ve played against him a few times, for United against Real and for England against Brazil. Everybody talks about how great Roberto Carlos is going forward but, that night especially, he proved he could defend too. He’s the best left-back in soccer. People say that he leaves space behind him because he bombs forward all the time, but the bloke can give people five-and ten-yard starts and still get back to make the tackle. I always loved games against him: if it was Roberto Carlos, then it was either Real Madrid or Brazil. You knew you and your team-mates were up against just about the best in the world.

After crashing out of Europe, the important thing was not to sit around feeling sorry for ourselves, however desperate we’d been to prove ourselves by winning the European Cup again. I think one of our strengths, and something that always set United apart, is how we reacted to a defeat. It’s a special spirit: during games, the team doesn’t know when it’s beaten. And when we did lose a game, however big the disappointment, you knew everybody would be back next match to make up for it. It’s the same spirit that fires up United teams to go on the kind of long unbeaten runs, like in 1999/2000, that win championships. The manager has a lot to do with it. The coaching staff at United, as far back as Nobby Stiles and Eric Harrison, have always been able to inspire that attitude, too. Even in youth cup and ‘A’ team soccer, we always seemed to have the ability to come back from low points, in the course of individual games and after we’d suffered defeats.

You could call it stubbornness. We finished 1999/2000 as Premiership Champions. The unwillingness to settle for second best, that intensity and desire: they’re in the make-up of the club. At United, a professional attitude ran through everything we did. Whatever the secret was, I think it was particularly strong, particularly obvious, amongst the group that grew up together in the nineties: me, the Nevilles, Paul Scholes, Ryan Giggs and Nicky Butt. Roy Keane used to make fun of us, laughing about the ‘Class of ’92’, but, of all people, he’s the kind of player who recognizes when the other players in a team are up for the battle.

There was a sense of togetherness amongst us that I don’t think you could ever buy or recreate. It grew over time because we’d all been at United together for so long. We had complete faith in each other. None of us got carried away as individuals. The last thing we’d ever do was let one another down. And one thing was always the same: we lived for playing soccer—playing soccer for Manchester United. In recent years, especially since we